



MADAM RIDES THE BUS

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

About the Author: Vallikkannan

Vallikkannan (1920–2006) was a well-known Tamil writer, essayist, and children's author from Tamil Nadu, India. He wrote many stories, articles, and books for children that are simple, humorous, and full of keen observation of everyday life. His stories often highlight the innocence of childhood, curiosity, and small joys of ordinary people. He received several literary awards for his contributions to Tamil literature, especially for children's writing. In "Madam Rides the Bus," he beautifully captures a young girl's first adventurous journey and her emotional world.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- Childhood curiosity, innocence, and the spirit of adventure.
- The joy of small, new experiences in life.
- The contrast between a child's imaginative world and the harsh realities of life.
- Loneliness and the desire for freedom.
- The cycle of life and death observed through a child's eyes.

Values:

- Courage to step out of one's comfort zone and try new things.
- Importance of observation and curiosity in learning about life.

- Respect and kindness towards elders.
- Emotional maturity and sensitivity even at a young age.
- Finding joy in simple pleasures.
- Understanding that life and death are natural parts of existence.
- Responsibility and self-control (as shown by Valli).

2. Characters

Valli (Valiammai): The protagonist — an eight-year-old curious, confident, and determined girl. She is intelligent, observant, and full of life. She is also called “Madam” by the bus conductor.

Bus Conductor: A jolly, friendly, and helpful man who teases Valli affectionately and treats her with care.

Passengers: Various people on the bus — some friendly, some indifferent.

Old Woman: A passenger who talks to Valli but annoys her with her talk about age and safety.

Valli’s Mother and neighbours: They appear briefly, showing the protective adult world.

3. In-Depth Summary (Detailed and Long)

The story revolves around an eight-year-old girl named Valli who lives in a small village. She is very curious and observant. Every day, she watches the new bus that travels between her village and the nearest town (about six miles away). The bus passes by her house at regular intervals. The sight of the bus, the sound of its horn, and the happy passengers fascinate her greatly. She develops a strong desire to ride the bus at least once.

Valli is a determined and self-reliant child. She carefully listens to conversations of neighbours who have travelled by bus. She collects every bit of information — the fare is

thirty paise one way, the trip takes two hours, and the bus timings. She saves money from her pocket money for six months by avoiding buying peppermints and toys. She does not tell anyone about her plan because she knows her mother and neighbours would stop her.

One day, when her mother is asleep in the afternoon, Valli quietly slips out of the house and boards the bus. She confidently tells the conductor, "I want to go to the town." The conductor is amused by her confidence and calls her "Madam." He offers her a seat and treats her with respect and affection. Valli enjoys every moment of the journey. She looks out of the window with great excitement. She sees canals, palm trees, grasslands, distant hills, and green fields. She refuses to take help from others and proudly pays the fare herself.

Inside the bus, an old woman tries to talk to her and warns her about travelling alone. Valli finds the old woman annoying because she looks dirty and keeps talking about dangers. Valli prefers to enjoy the scenery rather than listen to her. The bus reaches the town. Valli gets down and looks around the market. She sees toys, balloons, and sweets but does not buy anything because she wants to save money for the return ticket. After a short time, she boards the same bus for the return journey.

On the way back, the bus passes the same beautiful scenes, but this time Valli sees something sad. She notices a dead cow lying by the roadside. Earlier on the outward journey, she had seen the same cow alive and happy, running in the fields. The sight of the dead cow deeply affects her. It makes her think about the reality of death and how quickly life can end. Her cheerful mood becomes quiet and thoughtful.

When she reaches home, she quietly enters the house. Her mother is still sleeping and does not know about her adventure. Valli feels satisfied and happy with her secret journey. She has successfully fulfilled her long-cherished dream.

The story ends with Valli's innocent yet mature reflections on life, showing how a simple bus ride became a memorable and eye-opening experience for her.

4. Moral (in points)

- Curiosity and the spirit of adventure help us explore and enjoy life.
- Self-confidence and careful planning can help us achieve our small dreams.
- We should be responsible and careful while fulfilling our wishes.

- Simple joys like a bus ride can bring more happiness than expensive things.
- Life and death are natural; we must learn to accept this reality.
- Observation and sensitivity make us more mature and understanding.
- Independence should be balanced with safety and wisdom.
- Elders may worry, but children also need space to grow through experiences.

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